

Proctor Grading Guide & Rubric

Level-based scoring — Associate · Professional · Expert

Associate

Right product, generic reasoning
— knows *what*.

Professional

Correct product + how it
addresses the concern — knows
how.

Expert

Cedarline-specific reasoning,
outcome & HMF fit — knows
why.

Cedarline Health Group is a regional healthcare payer-provider — roughly 8,000 employees across four hospitals and thirty-one clinics, plus a claims-processing business that handles the money. Growth by acquisition (including a second data centre absorbed as-is) and a mid-flight, disorderly move to public cloud have left a fragmented security posture. After a security incident in March, the board asked what would have stopped it — and leadership still cannot answer. Budget and executive attention are approved, but explicitly temporary, and the security team is small.

Grading, step by step

- 1 For each pain point, read the team's **Product / platform** and **Solution-Engineer response** together.
- 2 Match the answer to the highest level it fully meets on the **master rubric** below (Associate → Professional → Expert).
- 3 Assign points **within that level's band** (0–25) — use the top of the band for a complete answer, the bottom when it only partly meets the level.
- 4 Repeat for all four pain points, then **add them for the Case Study total (/100)** and read off the Case Study level.
- 5 Write **feedback** for the Case Study: what the team did well, and where they can improve.
- 6 Carry the four Case Study totals to the **score summary** for the overall result (/400) and overall level.

Master rubric — how to place any answer (per pain point, 0–25)

LEVEL	WHAT THE ANSWER DEMONSTRATES	POINTS
Expert the goal	Correct product and capability; reasoning is specific to Cedarline's constraints (regulated/EU-AI-Act data, encrypted-traffic compliance limits, ~10k-rule segmentation failures, two-engineer team, three cloud policy models, inherited rulebase); states the outcome / how it helps ; connects into the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.	21–25
Professional	Correct, appropriate product; explains how it addresses the concern with sound Cisco Secure / HMF reasoning; shows some Cedarline context but may miss the outcome or the broader architecture tie-in.	14–20
Associate	Names a plausible/appropriate product and identifies the problem, but the reasoning is generic, partial, or product-name-only — the "how" is thin or missing.	6–13
Not yet	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no supporting reasoning.	0–5

Grading principles. Reward reasoning over product-name-matching — a right product with no "how" caps at Associate. Reward specificity to Cedarline over generic best-practice. Partial credit is fine: score the level the answer actually reaches, not the one it gestures at. Be consistent across teams for the same pain point.

Level bands

Associate

Case Study 40–64 /100
Overall 160–259 /400

Professional

Case Study 65–84 /100
Overall 260–339 /400

Expert

Case Study 85–100 /100
Overall 340–400 /400

Below Associate (Case Study < 40 / Overall < 160): Developing — the team has started but has not yet consistently reached Associate-level reasoning.

AI Security

Expected answers by level for each pain point. Use these as the yardstick — they are built from the solution guide. Score each pain point /25, then complete the feedback and total at the end.

PAIN POINT 1

Under the EU AI Act, we are classified as a 'Provider' for our internal AI systems. We need to demonstrate robustness and cybersecurity compliance to satisfy Article 15. How does Cisco help us meet these specific requirements?

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It automates the technical evidence gathering required for "Conformity Assessments." By mapping AI-specific threats to standardized frameworks (like MITRE ATLAS and OWASP), it provides the documentation and continuous monitoring necessary to prove to regulators that your systems are robust and compliant. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names AI Defense (AI Model and Application Validation) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco AI Defense is specifically designed to support Provider obligations under the EU AI Act. We utilize algorithmic red teaming technology for AI Model & App Validation, which identifies safety and security vulnerabilities at scale.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names AI Defense as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · **Level:** ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 2

We are integrating various open-source models and third-party agents into our internal workflows. How can we ensure these assets aren't introducing vulnerabilities into our environment before they even go live?

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It enables "Shift-Left" security by creating an inventory of all AI models and agents. By identifying vulnerabilities before production, it prevents the introduction of malicious code or poisoned data into your ecosystem. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names AI Defense (Supply Chain Risk Management) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco AI Defense addresses this through proactive Supply Chain Risk Management. We scan your model files, repositories, and MCP servers to identify malicious or unsafe assets.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names AI Defense as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 3

We know AI is showing up across our cloud environments faster than security can track it. We're worried we have models, agents, datasets, and MCP-connected tools running without visibility or consistent controls.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — identifies rogue or unsanctioned AI assets Maps relationships across data, models, agents, and tools Gives security teams a single-pane-of-glass view of AI exposure Helps close gaps before unknown AI usage becomes a production risk. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Cisco AI Defense - AI Cloud Visibility (Ai Cloud Visibility) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's exactly the visibility gap Cisco AI Defense is built to solve. With AI Cloud Visibility, Cisco AI Defense continuously discovers AI assets across distributed cloud environments, including models, agents, datasets, MCP servers, and agent-to-tool workflows.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Cisco AI Defense - AI Cloud Visibility as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

We're running AI workloads in cloud accounts, but we don't have a reliable way to see which models and AI assets are actually in use. We're also concerned about workloads reaching out to third-party AI models without security knowing about it. And even when we do know the traffic path, we need a practical way to inspect and enforce guardrails on prompt and response traffic in the cloud without changing every application.

Expert
21–25 pts

Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Finds AI assets in cloud accounts Identifies third-party AI model usage Uses existing cloud-network control points for enforcement Avoids relying only on application-level changes. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.

Professional
14–20 pts

Names AI Defense = AI visibility and guardrail integration Multicloud Defense = cloud account connection, traffic visibility, policy attachment, and egress enforcement (AI Runtime Protection) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's exactly what the AI Defense-Multicloud Defense integration is designed to address. Cisco AI Defense uses the integration to discover AI assets in your cloud environments and identify external AI destinations your workloads are calling.

Associate
6–13 pts

Names AI Defense = AI visibility and guardrail integration Multicloud Defense = cloud account connection, traffic visibility, policy attachment, and egress enforcement as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.

Not yet
0–5 pts

Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

✓ What the team did well

→ Where they can improve

Case Study 1 total _____ / 100

Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert ☐ Developing

Cloud Edge

Expected answers by level for each pain point. Use these as the yardstick — they are built from the solution guide. Score each pain point /25, then complete the feedback and total at the end.

PAIN POINT 1

If a breach occurs in one of our public cloud instances, we are terrified that the attacker will move laterally into our core on-premises systems. How can we contain these threats in a multicloud environment?

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It provides granular visibility and control over east-west traffic. By applying Zero Trust principles across the hybrid fabric, you transform your network into a series of secure, isolated zones that prevent an attacker from pivoting through your infrastructure. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Multicloud Defense (Multicloud Defense Gateways) and explains how it addresses the concern: Multicloud Defense leverages macro and micro-segmentation capabilities to enforce strict communication boundaries. By integrating with our Hybrid Mesh Firewall and Hypershield, we can isolate workloads and inspect traffic between cloud segments, effectively stopping lateral movement before it reaches your sensitive data.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Multicloud Defense as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 2

Our auditors require proof that our security controls are applied consistently across all our cloud workloads. Gathering this data from different cloud providers is a manual, time-consuming nightmare.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It automates the collection of evidence for security audits. By consolidating logs and policy enforcement data, you create a "single source of truth" that simplifies compliance reporting and demonstrates proactive governance to regulators. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Multicloud Defense (Multicloud Defense Visibility) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco Multicloud Defense provides unified logging and traceability. Because our security framework is integrated across the network fabric, you can generate consolidated reports that map directly to your compliance requirements (such as NIS2 or DORA) across all cloud environments from a single dashboard.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Multicloud Defense as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 3

We have workloads spread across AWS, Azure, and on-premises data centers. Managing security policies individually in each cloud environment is creating massive operational overhead and leading to inconsistent security posture.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It replaces siloed, manual configuration with centralized orchestration. By abstracting the security policy from the cloud-native tools, it ensures that your security posture is uniform and eliminates the "configuration drift" that occurs when managing multiple cloud consoles. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Multicloud Defense (Unified Security across public clouds) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco Multicloud Defense, integrated within our Hybrid Mesh Firewall architecture, provides a unified control plane. You can define security policies once via Security Cloud Control and enforce them consistently across your entire distributed environment, regardless of the underlying cloud provider.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Multicloud Defense as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

We have workloads on-prem, in cloud, and in mixed environments, and policy consistency is becoming difficult. Every environment feels different, and we're worried about drift.

Expert
21–25 pts

Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Reduces policy drift across hybrid and multicloud environments Aligns policy to application behavior, not just static IP-based rules Supports consistent macro and micro controls together. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.

Professional
14–20 pts

Names Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall Cisco Secure Firewall Management Center (FMC) Cisco Security Cloud Control (Secure Workload Integration with Secure Firewall Management Center) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's a common hybrid environment challenge. Cisco Secure Workload helps create a more unified segmentation model by using application dependency awareness and AI/ML-driven policy discovery to define policy based on how workloads actually communicate.

Associate
6–13 pts

Names Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall Cisco Secure Firewall Management Center (FMC) Cisco Security Cloud Control as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.

Not yet
0–5 pts

Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

✓ What the team did well

→ Where they can improve

Case Study 2 total _____ / 100

Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert ☐ Developing

3

CASE STUDY 3 · GRADING

DC Edge — Perimeter Firewall

Expected answers by level for each pain point. Use these as the yardstick — they are built from the solution guide. Score each pain point /25, then complete the feedback and total at the end.

PAIN POINT 1

When our security tools detect a compromised device, our manual response time is too slow. By the time we identify the user and manually isolate the port, the attacker has already moved through the network.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — It automates the "Response" phase of the incident lifecycle. By bridging the gap between detection and enforcement, it stops threats at the speed of the network. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names ISE (Security Group Tags (pxGrid integration)) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco ISE integrates with your security ecosystem via pxGrid and Adaptive Network Control (ANC). When a threat is detected, ISE can automatically trigger a quarantine policy, isolating the compromised device in real-time without requiring manual intervention.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names ISE as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 2

Our firewall environment has become too complex to manage manually.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Reduces manual policy review; identifies redundant/stale rules; lowers risk from human error. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Cisco Security Cloud Control, FMC, FTD (Unified Policy Administration) and explains how it addresses the concern: Cisco applies AI-driven analysis to firewall telemetry and policy data to surface optimization opportunities, reduce manual troubleshooting, and guide cleaner policy administration.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Cisco Security Cloud Control, FMC, FTD as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 3

Most of our traffic is encrypted, so we've lost visibility into a huge part of our environment.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Restores visibility into encrypted blind spots; avoids the performance/privacy overhead of decrypt-everything strategies. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control (EVE) and explains how it addresses the concern: Encrypted Visibility Engine (EVE) uses AI/ML-based fingerprinting to analyze encrypted traffic patterns and identify suspicious behavior without decrypting the payload.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 4

We're worried traditional signature-based detection won't catch new or unknown attacks quickly enough.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Addresses the gap between known and unknown threat detection; reduces dependence on signature timing. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control (Snort ML) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's exactly where Snort ML helps. It adds machine-learning-based detection inside the Snort 3 engine to identify exploit behavior associated with unknown/zero-day threats.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Cisco Secure Firewall (FTD), FMC, Security Cloud Control as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

✓ What the team did well

→ Where they can improve

4

CASE STUDY 4 · GRADING

Macro & Micro Segmentation

Expected answers by level for each pain point. Use these as the yardstick — they are built from the solution guide. Score each pain point /25, then complete the feedback and total at the end.

PAIN POINT 1

Network policy helps, but we also need to know what's happening at runtime inside the workload. We need better detection of suspicious behavior and policy violations.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Adds runtime visibility beyond basic network controls Detects suspicious system and network behavior in real time Strengthens Kubernetes security with deeper workload-level insight. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Isovalent (Tetragon Runtime Security) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's where Tetragon comes in. Tetragon extends the value of Cilium by providing eBPF-based runtime security and threat detection.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Isovalent as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 2

Our Kubernetes networking feels fragmented across clusters and environments. We're dealing with too many moving parts, inconsistent policies, and too much operational complexity.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Replaces brittle, IP-centric networking models with a Kubernetes-native approach Improves consistency across dynamic cluster environments Reduces operational complexity with a more unified networking and policy layer. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names — (Cilium Networking Policies) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's exactly where Isovalent Cilium helps. Cilium provides a modern, eBPF-based Kubernetes networking layer that gives you consistent connectivity, policy enforcement, and visibility across clusters and environments.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names — as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

PAIN POINT 3

Right now we're stitching together separate tools for networking, security, and observability in Kubernetes, and it's creating too much overhead.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Consolidates multiple functions into one platform approach Reduces tool sprawl and operational friction Improves context sharing between networking, security, and operations teams. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names cilium and tetragon and explains how it addresses the concern: That's exactly the consolidation opportunity Isovalent addresses. With Cilium for networking and policy, and Tetragon for runtime security, you get a more unified platform for connectivity, segmentation, observability, and security.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names cilium and tetragon as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

We know we need microsegmentation, but we don't have enough visibility into east-west flows or application dependencies to create policy safely. We don't want to break the application.

Expert 21–25 pts	Everything at Professional, plus reasoning tied to Cedarline's constraints and the stated outcome — Reveals actual application communication paths Reduces the risk of segmentation causing outages Enables more precise policy design and staged enforcement. Positions it within the wider Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
Professional 14–20 pts	Names Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall (Application dependency mapping) and explains how it addresses the concern: That's one of the biggest reasons customers adopt Cisco Secure Workload. It gives you deep visibility into workload communication and application dependency mapping, so you can see how applications actually behave before enforcing policy.
Associate 6–13 pts	Names Cisco Secure Workload Cisco Secure Firewall as relevant, but the response is generic — the product is stated without explaining how it addresses this specific concern.
Not yet 0–5 pts	Blank, off-topic, or a wrong product with no reasoning.

Score _____ / 25 · Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

✓ What the team did well

→ Where they can improve

Case Study 4 total _____ / 100

Level: ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert ☐ Developing

Team result

Team _____ Event _____

CASE STUDY	SCORE /100	LEVEL
1. AI Security	_____	☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert
2. Cloud Edge	_____	☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert
3. DC Edge — Perimeter Firewall	_____	☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert
4. Macro & Micro Segmentation	_____	☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert
Overall total	_____ / 400	☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert ☐ Developing

Overall feedback

✓ Strengths across the clinic

→ Priorities to develop

Overall level reminder. Expert 340–400 · Professional 260–339 · Associate 160–259 · Developing <160.
The level reflects the reasoning demonstrated, not just the product names chosen.